expected an American attack in the form of an air strike or a land invasion in the next one to three days, as Alekseev had reported earlier. Castro promised that the Cubans would "offer strong and decisive resistance to whatever form this aggression may take" but warned the Soviet leader that "the imperialists might initiate a nuclear strike against the USSR as well." "In those circumstances," continued Castro, "the moment would be right for considering the elimination of such a danger, claiming the lawful right to self-defense." In fact, he proposed that Khrushchev use nuclear weapons first. "However difficult and horrifying this decision may be, there is, I believe, no other recourse," wrote the Cuban leader.[11]

Alekseev, who took part in composing Castro's letter and subsequently found himself in trouble for having participated in such a warmongering exercise, denied that Castro wanted Khrushchev to attack the United States with nuclear weapons. "I think," said Alekseev later, in one of his interviews, "that he was just warning that we had to be on guard that anything could happen, including, as he thought, that the Americans could use nuclear weapons." That is not how Khrushchev read Castro's letter when he received it. His reaction to the Cuban's proposal would become steadily more negative over time. His original determination to use nuclear weapons against an American invasion force had long disappeared, yielding to a desire to avoid military conflict and thus nuclear war at almost any price.[12]

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THE FIRST MAJOR PIECE OF INFORMATION ON CUBA THAT Khrushchev saw on Saturday, October 27, was not Castro's alarmist letter but a calmer if still very disturbing report from the commander of the Soviet forces in Cuba, General Issa Pliev.

The general had clearly been affected by Castro's high anxiety. He also knew about the new DEFCON level and was disturbed by the increased American overflights. He reported that the Cubans were expecting an air strike either during the night of October 26 or on the morning of October 27. "The decision to shoot down American military airplanes with